Burdens Washed Away

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Mature

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Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora, Catra, Mara, Perfuma

Additional Tags:
Chronic Illness, catra has EDS, Ehlers-Danlos syndrome, Disability, Caregiving, bathing/shower assistance, Trans Catra (She-Ra), Hurt/Comfort, Medical Trauma, Angst with a sad ending, Choose Your Own Ending, the bad ending is ROUGH read at your own discretion, Autistic Catra (She-Ra)

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by weedcatra420

Summary

Catra's world is measured in pain: dislocated joints, crushing fatigue, and the relentless calculus of survival. A shower can cost her days. When Ehlers-Danlos Syndrome steals her independence, pride becomes a luxury she can't afford. Enter Mara, a caregiver whose steady hands and unwavering respect offer Catra something she'd forgotten – dignity.

Washing away the grime of illness, Mara helps Catra find moments of peace, even hope. But when the fragile lifeline of professional care is threatened by a system built on denial, Catra faces her deepest fear: being trapped once more in a body she can't care for. Adora stands by her side, but love alone can't navigate the labyrinth of insurance or ease the suffocating weight of despair.

This is a story of vulnerability, resilience, and the profound intimacy of care. It explores the fight for basic dignity against indifferent bureaucracy, the terrifying reliance on others, and the fragile spark of hope that can be found – or extinguished – in the simple act of being washed clean.

(Features both a Bad Ending and an Alternate Good Ending)

Notes

Hey, this is my first upload to AO3 so excuse any formatting/tagging weirdness as I figure it out. This is a story I wrote to process my own experiences. I hope it resonates with other people who might be going through something similar.

Bad Ending Version

Steps Forward

The morning light filtered through the blinds, casting stripes of gold across the bed where Catra lay, her tail twitching faintly under the weighted blanket. Her ears flattened as she shifted, a sharp hiss escaping her lips. Left hip again. She didn't need to look to know the joint had slipped halfway out of its socket overnight. Her body was a map of such betrayals.

Adora's voice floated from the kitchen, warm and steady. "Coffee's ready."

Catra grunted, gripping her cane, and levered herself upright. Her claws dug into the handle, grounding her. One. Two. Breathe. Standing was a negotiation, every muscle a reluctant participant.

In the kitchen, Adora stood in crisp work slacks, her blonde ponytail swinging as she portioned oatmeal into bowls. She didn't turn, didn't crowd. She knew better. "Big day," she said, casual, but Catra caught the undercurrent of worry.

"Video appointment at ten," Catra replied, her voice precise, syllables measured like stones placed carefully in a stream. She focused on the steam curling from her mug, the flecks of cinnamon in her oatmeal. Eye contact was a language she'd never learned, but Adora spoke hers fluently.

Catra propped her laptop on a pillow in the living room, the screen flickering to life with the clinic's logo. The doctor's face pixelated briefly before stabilizing. "Can you hear me okay?"

"Yeah," Catra said, adjusting her braces under the blanket. Her claws tapped the cane propped against the couch, a metronome

for her fraying patience.

The doctor’s voice crackled through the speakers. “You’ve been managing your EDS symptoms with rest?”

“Yes.” Her tail lashed once. Managing. A generous word for the calculus of survival: If I shower today, I lose tomorrow. If I walk to the store, I’ll collapse by evening. She recited her list—dislocations, muscle tears, the relentless fatigue—her tone detached, clinical. Only the tremor in her claws betrayed her.

The doctor nodded, a stilted movement on the lagging feed. “Let’s get you a referral. Short-term rehab can assist with bathing, PT, and connect you to long-term care."

Catra’s pulse thrummed. Help. A lifeline, or a surrender? Her claws tapped the cane. No. A tool. Like the braces hugging her knees, like Adora’s hand on her back during storms when the world was too loud.

Adora hovered in the doorway after the call ended, her work blazer discarded, sleeves rolled up. “How’d it go?”

Catra didn’t look up, her focus on shutting the laptop with too much force. “They’re sending someone. For… the shower. And other things.”

Adora crossed the room slowly, as if approaching a spooked animal. She sank onto the couch, leaving a careful gap between them. “Hey.” Her thumb brushed Catra’s wrist—safe, gentle—avoiding the tender joints. “Proud of you.”

Catra’s ears twitched, heat rising behind her ribs. Pride felt too vast, too bright. She leaned sideways until her temple met Adora’s shoulder, inhaling the scent of lavender detergent. “It’s just practical,” she muttered.

Adora laughed, the sound rumbling against her. “Sure, genius. Practical and brave.”

That night, Catra lay awake. The rehab agency would call tomorrow. Fear prickled—strangers in her space, hands on her fragile body—but beneath it, a spark. *A shower without pain. A day not lost to recovery.*

She curled closer to Adora, her purr a quiet rumble. For once, the future didn’t loom like a storm. It was a path, uneven but walkable, one step at a time.

The Weight of Water

Mara arrived at 2:03 PM—three minutes late, though her knock was soft, unhurried. Catra counted the footsteps from the couch, her claws kneading the cane’s grip. *Seven steps to the door. Turn the bolt. Don’t wobble.*

The woman on the threshold wore scrubs dotted with faded cartoon stars and carried a leather satchel smoothed to a shine by decades of use. Her eyes crinkled first, then her mouth. “Catra? I’m Mara.”

“You’re late,” Catra said, precise, ears pivoting backward. She gripped the doorframe.

Mara’s smile didn’t falter. “Traffic by the bridge.” She held up a clipboard. “Mind if we review your care plan?”

Catra hovered as Mara settled at the kitchen table, noting how the woman angled her body sideways—*not crowding, not staring.* She inhaled sharply. “Before we start. You read my file. About my…

anatomy." Her tail bristled, but she forced the words out, flat and clear. "I have a penis. Is that going to be a problem?"

Mara set down her pen. "Bodies are bodies. My only goal is to help yours feel better. If *you're* comfortable, I'm comfortable." She tilted her head. "Sound okay?"

Catra's shoulders loosened a fraction. "...Okay."

The bathroom fan hummed, muffling the clatter of Mara unpacking supplies—a shower stool, lavender-scented soap, towels so plush they made Catra's claws itch to sink into them. She stood frozen in the doorway, tail puffed.

"You set the pace," Mara said, adjusting the detachable showerhead. "We can skip anything that doesn't feel right. Deal?"

Catra nodded, her ears flat. Mara's hands were steady but never brisk as she helped unbutton Catra's loose pajama shirt, her touch lingering only to stabilize when Catra's shoulder joint protested. "Easy does it," she murmured, kneeling to slide sweatpants past Catra's hips, careful to avoid the tender curve of her knees.

When the first spray hit Catra's back, she flinched—not in pain, but at the shock of warmth. Heat seeped into knotted muscles she'd forgotten could unwind. She sank onto the stool, water sluicing over matted fur.

"Good?" Mara asked, gloved hands testing the temperature.

Catra's claws retracted slightly. The gloves helped. So did the rhythm—Mara narrating each step, never touching without warning. When warm soap circled between her shoulders, she startled, then… melted. No one had touched her this gently since the EDS stole her flexibility. Since pain became her shadow.

"Hair next?" Mara's voice was light, as if this were routine.

Catra blinked water from her lashes. “Yeah.”

The shampooing was almost transcendent—fingertips massaging her scalp, scritching the base of her ears just right. A rumble rose in her chest before she could stifle it, low and vibrating.

Mara chuckled. “Glad to hear it.”

Catra’s ears flushed, but she let the purr continue, too boneless to fight it.

The scariest part—Mara cleaning between her legs—was brisk, impersonal. “Need a break?” Mara asked, pausing as she rinsed Catra’s thighs.

“I'm okay,” Catra muttered, staring at the drain. But Mara’s gloves never strayed, never lingered. Just another patch of skin to wash.

Afterward, Mara toweled her off with the care of someone polishing porcelain—patting dry the dip of her spine, the tufted fur of her tail, even between her toes. “Arms up,” she instructed softly, helping Catra into a fresh hoodie, her fingers deft with the zipper. “Sweatpants or shorts today?”

“Pants,” Catra mumbled, bracing on Mara’s shoulder as she stepped in.

By the time they finished, the mirror had unfogged, and Catra’s reflection stared back—fluffed fur, eyes less sunken, the tension in her jaw softened.

Adora exploded through the door at 6:15 PM, takeout containers clutched to her chest. “Catra? How was—?” She froze.

Catra sat cross-legged on the couch, her damp fur combed into loose spikes, humming tunelessly as she restacked Adora's neglected puzzle pieces by color. Her tail swayed, a metronome of leftover energy.

Adora's eyes brimmed. "You're… glowing."

"It's just a shower," Catra muttered, but the corner of her mouth twitched.

Adora crouched before her, hands hovering. "Can I—?"

Catra leaned forward, letting their foreheads touch. Words lodged in her throat, too big, too raw.

"I was worried about you," Adora whispered. "How'd it go?"

Catra's breath hitched. "Better than… I didn't know it could feel like that. Being cared for. Not weak. Just… *worth it*."

Adora's thumbs swept her cheeks, catching tears Catra hadn't named. "You've always been worth it."

Catra nuzzled into her palm, the purr building again, loud and unguarded. Maybe tomorrow would bring dislocations, fatigue, the old shame creeping back. But here, now—clean fur, Adora's heartbeat under her cheek—felt like a threshold crossed.

A beginning.

Drops in the Bucket

Weeks blurred into routine. Every Thursday at 2:00 PM, Mara arrived—never late again—with her star-patterned scrubs and satchel smelling of lemongrass sanitizer. Catra stopped counting the footsteps to the door.

“Catra’s Salon of Misery, now open,” she muttered once, leaning on her cane as Mara unpacked the shower stool. The jab felt safer than admitting how fiercely she’d waited for this.

Mara snorted. “Misery? With that fur? I’ve seen showroom cats with less gloss.”

The routine was clinical, yet intimate. Mara’s hands steadied Catra’s elbow as pajamas slipped to the floor, her touch pausing only to adjust when Catra’s shoulder clicked out of place. The shower spray hit Catra’s back, and she exhaled—a slow, measured release of tension.

Small talk came in fragments.

“Do a lot of your clients use mobility aids?” Catra asked one session, watching Mara adjust the detachable showerhead.

“Quite a few. Canes, wheelchairs. A few service dogs.”

“Dogs.” Catra’s ear twitched.

“One golden retriever ate my shoelaces.”
Catra’s laugh surprised them both—short, sharp, a bark swallowed by the drain.

Adora brought home sunflowers after the fourth shower. “For the bathroom,” she said, arranging them in a mason jar. “Color’s nice.”

Catra pretended not to notice the tremor in her hands. Adora had been crying in the stairwell again. Relief, maybe. Or grief for all the years Catra spent bedridden in hoodies crusted with old sweat.

“They’re weeds,” Catra said, flicking a petal.

“Weeds need light too,” Adora replied, too gently.

Mara found the Social Security denial letter under a pile of medical bills. Catra's claws shot out, fur bristling. "Don't—!"

"None of my business," Mara said, raising her palms. But later, toweling Catra's ears: "My cousin's a disability advocate. She could cut that paperwork hell in half."

Catra's tail lashed. "I don't need pity."

"Nah. You need a crowbar. Those government nerds thrive on wearing folks down."

For three years, Catra had gnawed at applications alone, red tape clotting her throat. Now, the offer sat between them, warm as the steam on the mirror.

"...Email me her info," Catra said finally.

"On it."

Adora came home early once, catching Catra mid-puzzle—a 1000-piece galaxy sprawled across the floor. Her cane lay discarded, hips braced against the couch.

"Since when do you like space?" Adora breathed.

"Since the shower stool means I can *sit* longer," Catra grumbled, but her ears tilted up. Three months ago, bending to pick up a piece would've dislocated her shoulder.

Adora knelt, slotted a star fragment into place. "Looks good."

"It's upside down."

"Artistic choice."

The ache in Catra's ribs had nothing to do with subluxations. Hope, she realized, could bruise too.

At breakfast, Catra stared at her reflection in the spoon. "What if I tried... leaving the apartment?"

Adora choked on her coffee. "Like… the farmers' market? There's ramps—"

"Don't make it weird. Just the mailbox." But her claws tapped the table. *Further. Farther.*

Adora beamed, sunrise-bright. "Mail's a start."

Catra's world still fit inside 800 square feet. But Mara's hands had widened it by centimeters—clean fur, small talk, the sharp *click* of a puzzle piece snapped into place. At night, she dreamt of walking —not running, just walking—down a street where the cracks didn't threaten to swallow her whole.

Hope was a cautious thing. A Shower Stool. Sunflowers. A ramp she hadn't used yet.

But it was there.

Thresholds

Catra counted the calendar squares in red marker—*four sessions left*—before crumpling the paper into her nightstand drawer. Mara's laugh echoed from the bathroom as she prepped the shower, unaware of the number burning behind Catra's ribs.

"Water's ready when you are," Mara called.

Catra's claws snagged the carpet. *Act normal. Don't be weird.* But her tail lashed as Mara helped her undress, the silence thicker than steam.

"Shoulder's stiff today?" Mara asked, testing the joint's range.

"No."

"Hm." Mara's hands stilled. "Something else, then."

Catra stared at the drain, water pooling around the stool. "You're leaving soon."

Mara adjusted the showerhead, her voice casual. "Transition's part of the job. But we've got time to—"

"Don't." Catra's ears flattened. "Don't do the 'everything's fine' script. I *hate* starting over. New people, new… *everything*." Her voice frayed, precise syllables cracking. "What if they're not—what if they *care* wrong?"

Mara turned off the water. The sudden quiet rang louder. "You're right. It sucks." She handed Catra a towel, her gaze steady. "Long-term care's a maze, but here's the plan: I refer you to an agency. You'll meet aides beforehand, pick who clicks. They'll get your file—anatomy, EDS protocols, the works. No surprises."

Catra's claws pricked the towel. "What if no one… *fits*?"

"Then we try again." Mara's smile softened. "You're the boss here, Catra. Always."

The word *boss* lodged in Catra's throat. She'd spent years feeling hostage to her body, to bureaucrats, to the four walls of the apartment. Now, this—*choice*—felt foreign, almost dangerous.

"I'll set up the referral this week," Mara added. "Walk you through it next time."

Catra nodded, her damp fur trembling. "Okay."

Adora found her later, curled on the couch with a half-finished puzzle—a galaxy missing its center. She hovered in the doorway, reading the tension in Catra's hunched shoulders. "Bad day?"

"Mara's leaving," Catra said, too sharp.

Adora stilled. "Oh. Shit."

"She's helping me find someone else. Says I get to choose."

"That's… good?"

"Is it?" Catra's laugh bit. "What if I choose wrong? What if they *touch* wrong, or stare, or—"

Adora sat carefully, not reaching. "You survived me."

Catra blinked. "What?"

"When we met. I kept hugging you without asking. You bit me."

"You *were* annoying."

"Still am." Adora's grin faded. "But you taught me. You'll teach them too."

Catra's tail flicked, restless. Teaching meant trust. Trust meant risk. But Mara's words hummed beneath the fear: *You're the boss.*

She slid a puzzle piece into place—a shard of starlight. "Maybe."

Adora didn't push. Just sat, breathing in tandem, until Catra's purr rumbled tentative and low.

That night, Catra dreamt of a door. Not the apartment's, but something wider, with a ramp she hadn't built yet. Mara stood

beside it, holding a toolbox.

"*Your turn,*" she said, and vanished.

Catra woke, joints screaming, but the dream lingered—a blueprint etched behind her eyelids.

A threshold. A choice.

A galaxy waiting to be pieced together.

The Unraveling

Mara's knock came at 2:00 PM sharp. Catra didn't look up from the puzzle, her tail flicking with forced calm. *Three weeks left*, she reminded herself. Mara would handle the referral. Mara *always* handled things.

But the caregiver's satchel hit the table with a thud heavier than usual. "Got some bad news."

Catra's ears twitched. "Define 'bad.'"

"Insurance denied the long-term care referral. Says bathing assistance isn't covered under your plan."

The puzzle piece in Catra's claws snapped. "But you—you said you'd fix it."

"I'm trying." Mara's voice softened. "We'll appeal, but—"

"But *what*?" Catra stood too fast, her knee buckling. Mara caught her elbow, but she jerked away. "I can't— I can't do this again. I can't go back to *filth*—"

Adora's key turned in the lock. "Hey, I brought…" She froze, takeout bag dripping onto the tiles.

"Get. Out." Catra's snarl cracked.

They left.

Mara found Catra hunched over the phone, insurance hold music screeching. "*Your estimated wait time is*…"

"Hungry?" Mara held out a granola bar.

"They've transferred me *six times*," Catra hissed, ignoring the offering. "Everyone says it's not their department. Not their problem." The shower stool waited in the bathroom, but Catra didn't move. "You promised this would work."

"I promised to try." Mara's patience chafed like a raw nerve. "Undress. Let's get you cleaned up."

"What's the *point*?" Catra's tail lashed, scattering medical bills. "I'll just stink again in a month."

Mara's jaw tightened. "The point is *today*. Your choice."

Catra chose the shower. The water scalded, Mara's gloves felt clumsy, and when the shampoo touched her scalp, Catra bit back a sob. *Too good. Too late*.

Adora had hidden the phone charger. Catra found it, jammed the cord into the wall, and dialed again.

"*We don't accept EDS as a qualifying condition*."

Click.

Mara arrived to Catra crouched in the shower, fur matted, her cane abandoned on the floor. “Called twelve agencies,” she muttered as Mara turned on the water. “Two hung up. One laughed.”

Mara’s hands paused. “Let me help you find—”

“You *did* help.” Catra’s laugh was hollow. “And now you’re leaving.”

The shower passed in silence. Mara dried her, dressed her, left a list of numbers on the fridge. Catra didn’t look at them.

Adora came home to darkness. No puzzle pieces. No purring. Just Catra curled in bed, knees drawn to her chest, the hoodie she’d worn for two weeks straight clinging to her fur.

“Mara texted,” Adora whispered. “She’s coming tomorrow to…”

“Don’t.” Catra’s voice was muffled.

Adora lay beside her, stiff, careful. “I’m here. I’m not going anywhere.”

Catra didn’t answer. The care had been a crack of light—proof she was worth the effort. Now the crack was closing, and the dark felt heavier.

That night, she dreamt of drowning. No shower stool, no hands. Just water filling her lungs.

The Final Ripple

Mara’s Final Visit

The shower water drummed uselessly against Catra's hunched shoulders, the stool creaking under her weight. Mara knelt beside her, gloves slick with soap, waiting for a flinch, a snarl, anything. But Catra's eyes stayed hollow, fixed on the drain.

"I..." she whispered.

Mara turned off the water. "What?"

"I trusted you." The words were frail, fractured. "You made me think… I was *worth* this. Now you're just… gone." Her claws dug into the shower stool. "Back to filth. Back to nothing."

Mara's composure slipped—a blink too long, a wobble in her throat. "Catra, I—"

"Everyone leaves. That's the *rule*." A sob cracked through her, sudden and ragged. "But I let myself believe you were different."

Mara reached, then pulled back. "This system—it's not built for people like you. That's not your fault."

"Doesn't *matter*." Catra's laugh was a wet, broken thing. "I'm the one who drowns in it."

The towel felt like a shroud. Mara dressed her in silence, fingers lingering only to stabilize Catra's trembling hip. At the door, Mara hesitated, satchel slung over her shoulder like a flag of surrender.

Catra's voice pierced the quiet: "…Thank you. For trying."

Mara didn't turn. "I'm sorry I couldn't do more."

She left.

Adora found Catra on the bathroom floor, still damp, knees pressed to her chest. She didn't resist when Adora lifted her,

carried her to bed, curled around her like a vise.

"Talk to me," Adora begged. "Please."

Catra stared past her. Words were ash. Thoughts were scissors, snipping the threads that kept her tethered.

The shower was mercy. Clean meant hope. Now…

Adora's breath hitched against her neck. "Don't leave me."

But how do I stay?

Catra's mind clawed at the walls. A bottle of pills in the cabinet. The window latch. Adora's steak knives. No. Not knives. Too messy. Too cruel. But the relief—to stop *fighting*, to trickle out quietly, painlessly—

She'd blame herself.

Adora's grip tightened. "I love you. We'll figure this out."

You can't.

But Catra's hand found Adora's, squeezed once. A lie. A plea.

The night stretched, endless and suffocating. In the dark, Catra mapped exits. In the dark, Adora counted her breaths.

Bad Ending: The Weight of Silence

The shower stool gathered dust in the corner. Catra stopped counting days. Her fur matted into clumps, the smell sharp and sour, but she barely noticed. Adora left clean clothes on the bed—hoodies, soft pants—but Catra wore the same sweat-stained shirt until the fabric frayed.

Adora tried.

She cooked broth, left it steaming on the nightstand. She read aloud from Catra's old comics, voice cracking over punchlines that died in the stillness. She cried in the shower, muffled by the water, but Catra's ears caught every hitched breath.

"Please," Adora whispered one night, forehead pressed to Catra's unwashed back. "*Please*."

Catra didn't answer. Words required energy. Energy required hope.

The pills were in the bathroom cabinet, hidden behind expired cold medicine. Catra found them during a rare moment of standing, her knees screaming as she gripped the sink. The bottle rattled—a soft, promising sound.

Peace.

Not happiness. Not hope. Just… an end to the ache in her joints, the shame in her fur, the guilt of watching Adora's light gutter out.

She sat on the toilet lid, turning the bottle in her claws. *Trazodone. Take one daily for sleep*. Adora's prescription, half-empty.

"It won't hurt her if I'm just… gone," she lied to herself. "Better than this."

But she knew. Knew Adora would find her. Knew Adora would fracture. But the alternative—years more of decay, of being a burden, of *waiting* for a mercy that never came—

Catra unscrewed the cap.

Adora came home to silence.

No puzzle pieces. No ragged breathing. Just Catra curled on their bed, fur dull, eyes closed. The empty bottle gleamed on the nightstand.

Adora stood frozen, her keys slipping from her fingers. She didn't scream. Didn't shake her. Just knelt, pressed two fingers to Catra's throat, and waited. When no pulse answered, she folded forward, forehead resting on the edge of the mattress, her breath coming in silent, shuddering waves.

Paramedics heaved Catra onto a gurney, their faces grim. Adora followed, clutching Catra's limp hand, repeating "*Stay with me, stay with me*" like a prayer.

But Catra was already gone.

The Unanswered

The funeral was small. Just a plain pine box and a handful of strangers who'd never known Catra's laugh, her claws, the way she purred when her fur was clean.

The obituary said *chronic illness*. The truth was simpler:

A world that refused to care, and a body that could not endure its indifference.

Good Ending Version

Steps Forward

The morning light filtered through the blinds, casting stripes of gold across the bed where Catra lay, her tail twitching faintly under the weighted blanket. Her ears flattened as she shifted, a sharp hiss escaping her lips. Left hip again. She didn't need to look to know the joint had slipped halfway out of its socket overnight. Her body was a map of such betrayals.

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In the kitchen, Adora stood in crisp work slacks, her blonde ponytail swinging as she portioned oatmeal into bowls. She didn't turn, didn't crowd. She knew better. "Big day," she said, casual, but Catra caught the undercurrent of worry.

"Video appointment at ten," Catra replied, her voice precise, syllables measured like stones placed carefully in a stream. She focused on the steam curling from her mug, the flecks of cinnamon in her oatmeal. Eye contact was a language she'd never learned, but Adora spoke hers fluently.

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The doctor nodded, a stilted movement on the lagging feed. “Let’s get you a referral. Short-term rehab can assist with bathing, PT, and connect you to long-term care."

Catra’s pulse thrummed. Help. A lifeline, or a surrender? Her claws tapped the cane. No. A tool. Like the braces hugging her knees, like Adora’s hand on her back during storms when the world was too loud.

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Mara set down her pen. "Bodies are bodies. My only goal is to help yours feel better. If *you're* comfortable, I'm comfortable." She tilted her head. "Sound okay?"

Catra's shoulders loosened a fraction. "...Okay."

The bathroom fan hummed, muffling the clatter of Mara unpacking supplies—a shower stool, lavender-scented soap, towels so plush they made Catra's claws itch to sink into them. She stood frozen in the doorway, tail puffed.

"You set the pace," Mara said, adjusting the detachable showerhead. "We can skip anything that doesn't feel right. Deal?"

Catra nodded, her ears flat. Mara's hands were steady but never brisk as she helped unbutton Catra's loose pajama shirt, her touch lingering only to stabilize when Catra's shoulder joint protested. "Easy does it," she murmured, kneeling to slide sweatpants past Catra's hips, careful to avoid the tender curve of her knees.

When the first spray hit Catra's back, she flinched—not in pain, but at the shock of warmth. Heat seeped into knotted muscles she'd forgotten could unwind. She sank onto the stool, water sluicing over matted fur.

"Good?" Mara asked, gloved hands testing the temperature.

Catra's claws retracted slightly. The gloves helped. So did the rhythm—Mara narrating each step, never touching without warning. When warm soap circled between her shoulders, she startled, then… melted. No one had touched her this gently since the EDS stole her flexibility. Since pain became her shadow.

"Hair next?" Mara's voice was light, as if this were routine.

Catra blinked water from her lashes. “Yeah.”

The shampooing was almost transcendent—fingertips massaging her scalp, scritching the base of her ears just right. A rumble rose in her chest before she could stifle it, low and vibrating.

Mara chuckled. “Glad to hear it.”

Catra’s ears flushed, but she let the purr continue, too boneless to fight it.

The scariest part—Mara cleaning between her legs—was brisk, impersonal. “Need a break?” Mara asked, pausing as she rinsed Catra’s thighs.

“I'm okay,” Catra muttered, staring at the drain. But Mara’s gloves never strayed, never lingered. Just another patch of skin to wash.

Afterward, Mara toweled her off with the care of someone polishing porcelain—patting dry the dip of her spine, the tufted fur of her tail, even between her toes. “Arms up,” she instructed softly, helping Catra into a fresh hoodie, her fingers deft with the zipper. “Sweatpants or shorts today?”

“Pants,” Catra mumbled, bracing on Mara’s shoulder as she stepped in.

By the time they finished, the mirror had unfogged, and Catra’s reflection stared back—fluffed fur, eyes less sunken, the tension in her jaw softened.

Adora exploded through the door at 6:15 PM, takeout containers clutched to her chest. “Catra? How was—?” She froze.

Catra sat cross-legged on the couch, her damp fur combed into loose spikes, humming tunelessly as she restacked Adora's neglected puzzle pieces by color. Her tail swayed, a metronome of leftover energy.

Adora's eyes brimmed. "You're… glowing."

"It's just a shower," Catra muttered, but the corner of her mouth twitched.

Adora crouched before her, hands hovering. "Can I—?"

Catra leaned forward, letting their foreheads touch. Words lodged in her throat, too big, too raw.

"I was worried about you," Adora whispered. "How'd it go?"

Catra's breath hitched. "Better than… I didn't know it could feel like that. Being cared for. Not weak. Just… *worth it*."

Adora's thumbs swept her cheeks, catching tears Catra hadn't named. "You've always been worth it."

Catra nuzzled into her palm, the purr building again, loud and unguarded. Maybe tomorrow would bring dislocations, fatigue, the old shame creeping back. But here, now—clean fur, Adora's heartbeat under her cheek—felt like a threshold crossed.

A beginning.

Drops in the Bucket

Weeks blurred into routine. Every Thursday at 2:00 PM, Mara arrived—never late again—with her star-patterned scrubs and satchel smelling of lemongrass sanitizer. Catra stopped counting the footsteps to the door.

“Catra’s Salon of Misery, now open,” she muttered once, leaning on her cane as Mara unpacked the shower stool. The jab felt safer than admitting how fiercely she’d waited for this.

Mara snorted. “Misery? With that fur? I’ve seen showroom cats with less gloss.”

The routine was clinical, yet intimate. Mara’s hands steadied Catra’s elbow as pajamas slipped to the floor, her touch pausing only to adjust when Catra’s shoulder clicked out of place. The shower spray hit Catra’s back, and she exhaled—a slow, measured release of tension.

Small talk came in fragments.

“Do a lot of your clients use mobility aids?” Catra asked one session, watching Mara adjust the detachable showerhead.

“Quite a few. Canes, wheelchairs. A few service dogs.”

“Dogs.” Catra’s ear twitched.

“One golden retriever ate my shoelaces.”
Catra’s laugh surprised them both—short, sharp, a bark swallowed by the drain.

Adora brought home sunflowers after the fourth shower. “For the bathroom,” she said, arranging them in a mason jar. “Color’s nice.”

Catra pretended not to notice the tremor in her hands. Adora had been crying in the stairwell again. Relief, maybe. Or grief for all the years Catra spent bedridden in hoodies crusted with old sweat.

“They’re weeds,” Catra said, flicking a petal.

“Weeds need light too,” Adora replied, too gently.

Mara found the Social Security denial letter under a pile of medical bills. Catra's claws shot out, fur bristling. "Don't—!"

"None of my business," Mara said, raising her palms. But later, toweling Catra's ears: "My cousin's a disability advocate. She could cut that paperwork hell in half."

Catra's tail lashed. "I don't need pity."

"Nah. You need a crowbar. Those government nerds thrive on wearing folks down."

For three years, Catra had gnawed at applications alone, red tape clotting her throat. Now, the offer sat between them, warm as the steam on the mirror.

"...Email me her info," Catra said finally.

"On it."

Adora came home early once, catching Catra mid-puzzle—a 1000-piece galaxy sprawled across the floor. Her cane lay discarded, hips braced against the couch.

"Since when do you like space?" Adora breathed.

"Since the shower stool means I can *sit* longer," Catra grumbled, but her ears tilted up. Three months ago, bending to pick up a piece would've dislocated her shoulder.

Adora knelt, slotted a star fragment into place. "Looks good."

"It's upside down."

"Artistic choice."

The ache in Catra's ribs had nothing to do with subluxations. Hope, she realized, could bruise too.

At breakfast, Catra stared at her reflection in the spoon. "What if I tried... leaving the apartment?"

Adora choked on her coffee. "Like… the farmers' market? There's ramps—"

"Don't make it weird. Just the mailbox." But her claws tapped the table. *Further. Farther.*

Adora beamed, sunrise-bright. "Mail's a start."

Catra's world still fit inside 800 square feet. But Mara's hands had widened it by centimeters—clean fur, small talk, the sharp *click* of a puzzle piece snapped into place. At night, she dreamt of walking —not running, just walking—down a street where the cracks didn't threaten to swallow her whole.

Hope was a cautious thing. A Shower Stool. Sunflowers. A ramp she hadn't used yet.

But it was there.

Thresholds

Catra counted the calendar squares in red marker—*four sessions left*—before crumpling the paper into her nightstand drawer. Mara's laugh echoed from the bathroom as she prepped the shower, unaware of the number burning behind Catra's ribs.

"Water's ready when you are," Mara called.

Catra's claws snagged the carpet. *Act normal. Don't be weird.* But her tail lashed as Mara helped her undress, the silence thicker than steam.

"Shoulder's stiff today?" Mara asked, testing the joint's range.

"No."

"Hm." Mara's hands stilled. "Something else, then."

Catra stared at the drain, water pooling around the stool. "You're leaving soon."

Mara adjusted the showerhead, her voice casual. "Transition's part of the job. But we've got time to—"

"Don't." Catra's ears flattened. "Don't do the 'everything's fine' script. I *hate* starting over. New people, new… *everything*." Her voice frayed, precise syllables cracking. "What if they're not—what if they *care* wrong?"

Mara turned off the water. The sudden quiet rang louder. "You're right. It sucks." She handed Catra a towel, her gaze steady. "Long-term care's a maze, but here's the plan: I refer you to an agency. You'll meet aides beforehand, pick who clicks. They'll get your file—anatomy, EDS protocols, the works. No surprises."

Catra's claws pricked the towel. "What if no one… *fits*?"

"Then we try again." Mara's smile softened. "You're the boss here, Catra. Always."

The word *boss* lodged in Catra's throat. She'd spent years feeling hostage to her body, to bureaucrats, to the four walls of the apartment. Now, this—*choice*—felt foreign, almost dangerous.

"I'll set up the referral this week," Mara added. "Walk you through it next time."

Catra nodded, her damp fur trembling. "Okay."

Adora found her later, curled on the couch with a half-finished puzzle—a galaxy missing its center. She hovered in the doorway, reading the tension in Catra's hunched shoulders. "Bad day?"

"Mara's leaving," Catra said, too sharp.

Adora stilled. "Oh. Shit."

"She's helping me find someone else. Says I get to choose."

"That's… good?"

"Is it?" Catra's laugh bit. "What if I choose wrong? What if they *touch* wrong, or stare, or—"

Adora sat carefully, not reaching. "You survived me."

Catra blinked. "What?"

"When we met. I kept hugging you without asking. You bit me."

"You *were* annoying."

"Still am." Adora's grin faded. "But you taught me. You'll teach them too."

Catra's tail flicked, restless. Teaching meant trust. Trust meant risk. But Mara's words hummed beneath the fear: *You're the boss.*

She slid a puzzle piece into place—a shard of starlight. "Maybe."

Adora didn't push. Just sat, breathing in tandem, until Catra's purr rumbled tentative and low.

That night, Catra dreamt of a door. Not the apartment's, but something wider, with a ramp she hadn't built yet. Mara stood

beside it, holding a toolbox.

"*Your turn,*" she said, and vanished.

Catra woke, joints screaming, but the dream lingered—a blueprint etched behind her eyelids.

A threshold. A choice.

A galaxy waiting to be pieced together.

The Unraveling

Mara's knock came at 2:00 PM sharp. Catra didn't look up from the puzzle, her tail flicking with forced calm. *Three weeks left*, she reminded herself. Mara would handle the referral. Mara *always* handled things.

But the caregiver's satchel hit the table with a thud heavier than usual. "Got some bad news."

Catra's ears twitched. "Define 'bad.'"

"Insurance denied the long-term care referral. Says bathing assistance isn't covered under your plan."

The puzzle piece in Catra's claws snapped. "But you—you said you'd fix it."

"I'm trying." Mara's voice softened. "We'll appeal, but—"

"But *what*?" Catra stood too fast, her knee buckling. Mara caught her elbow, but she jerked away. "I can't— I can't do this again. I can't go back to *filth*—"

Adora's key turned in the lock. "Hey, I brought…" She froze, takeout bag dripping onto the tiles.

"Get. Out." Catra's snarl cracked.

They left.

Mara found Catra hunched over the phone, insurance hold music screeching. "*Your estimated wait time is*…"

"Hungry?" Mara held out a granola bar.

"They've transferred me *six times*," Catra hissed, ignoring the offering. "Everyone says it's not their department. Not their problem." The shower stool waited in the bathroom, but Catra didn't move. "You promised this would work."

"I promised to try." Mara's patience chafed like a raw nerve. "Undress. Let's get you cleaned up."

"What's the *point*?" Catra's tail lashed, scattering medical bills. "I'll just stink again in a month."

Mara's jaw tightened. "The point is *today*. Your choice."

Catra chose the shower. The water scalded, Mara's gloves felt clumsy, and when the shampoo touched her scalp, Catra bit back a sob. *Too good. Too late*.

Adora had hidden the phone charger. Catra found it, jammed the cord into the wall, and dialed again.

"*We don't accept EDS as a qualifying condition*."

Click.

Mara arrived to Catra crouched in the shower, fur matted, her cane abandoned on the floor. “Called twelve agencies,” she muttered as Mara turned on the water. “Two hung up. One laughed.”

Mara’s hands paused. “Let me help you find—”

“You *did* help.” Catra’s laugh was hollow. “And now you’re leaving.”

The shower passed in silence. Mara dried her, dressed her, left a list of numbers on the fridge. Catra didn’t look at them.

Adora came home to darkness. No puzzle pieces. No purring. Just Catra curled in bed, knees drawn to her chest, the hoodie she’d worn for two weeks straight clinging to her fur.

“Mara texted,” Adora whispered. “She’s coming tomorrow to…”

“Don’t.” Catra’s voice was muffled.

Adora lay beside her, stiff, careful. “I’m here. I’m not going anywhere.”

Catra didn’t answer. The care had been a crack of light—proof she was worth the effort. Now the crack was closing, and the dark felt heavier.

That night, she dreamt of drowning. No shower stool, no hands. Just water filling her lungs.

The Final Ripple

Mara’s Final Visit

The shower water drummed uselessly against Catra's hunched shoulders, the stool creaking under her weight. Mara knelt beside her, gloves slick with soap, waiting for a flinch, a snarl, anything. But Catra's eyes stayed hollow, fixed on the drain.

"I..." she whispered.

Mara turned off the water. "What?"

"I trusted you." The words were frail, fractured. "You made me think… I was *worth* this. Now you're just… gone." Her claws dug into the shower stool. "Back to filth. Back to nothing."

Mara's composure slipped—a blink too long, a wobble in her throat. "Catra, I—"

"Everyone leaves. That's the *rule*." A sob cracked through her, sudden and ragged. "But I let myself believe you were different."

Mara reached, then pulled back. "This system—it's not built for people like you. That's not your fault."

"Doesn't *matter*." Catra's laugh was a wet, broken thing. "I'm the one who drowns in it."

The towel felt like a shroud. Mara dressed her in silence, fingers lingering only to stabilize Catra's trembling hip. At the door, Mara hesitated, satchel slung over her shoulder like a flag of surrender.

Catra's voice pierced the quiet: "…Thank you. For trying."

Mara didn't turn. "I'm sorry I couldn't do more."

She left.

Adora found Catra on the bathroom floor, still damp, knees pressed to her chest. She didn't resist when Adora lifted her,

carried her to bed, curled around her like a vise.

"Talk to me," Adora begged. "Please."

Catra stared past her. Words were ash. Thoughts were scissors, snipping the threads that kept her tethered.

The shower was mercy. Clean meant hope. Now…

Adora's breath hitched against her neck. "Don't leave me."

But how do I stay?

Catra's mind clawed at the walls. A bottle of pills in the cabinet. The window latch. Adora's steak knives. No. Not knives. Too messy. Too cruel. But the relief—to stop *fighting*, to trickle out quietly, painlessly—

She'd blame herself.

Adora's grip tightened. "I love you. We'll figure this out."

You can't.

But Catra's hand found Adora's, squeezed once. A lie. A plea.

The night stretched, endless and suffocating. In the dark, Catra mapped exits. In the dark, Adora counted her breaths.

Good Ending: The Call

The shower stool gathered dust in the corner. Catra stopped counting days. Her fur matted into clumps, the smell sharp and sour, but she barely noticed. Adora left clean clothes on the bed—hoodies, soft pants—but Catra wore the same sweat-stained shirt until the fabric frayed.

Adora tried.

She cooked broth, left it steaming on the nightstand. She read aloud from Catra's old comics, voice cracking over punchlines that died in the stillness. She cried in the shower, muffled by the water, but Catra's ears caught every hitched breath.

"Please," Adora whispered one night, forehead pressed to Catra's unwashed back. "*Please*."

Catra didn't answer. Words required energy. Energy required hope.

The pill bottle felt lighter than it should. Catra shook it, listening to the rattle—a morbid lullaby. Her fur was matted, her joints screamed, but the ache in her chest was worse. *I'm a wound that won't close*.

She tipped the bottle.

The phone rang.

Catra froze. The screen flashed *Unknown Number*. She almost ignored it. Almost.

"Ms. D'riluth? This is Janet from Social Security. Your application's been approved. Including three years of back pay."

The bottle slipped from her claws. "What?"

"Benefits start next month. You'll receive a letter, but I wanted to call—"

Catra didn't hear the rest. The numbers blurred—*enough for aides, for help, for* ***living***. She collapsed against the bedframe, gasping, laughter and sobs tangling in her throat.

Adora found her there, knees pulled to her chest, phone clutched like a lifeline. "Catra? *Catra*—!"

"Social Security," Catra rasped, tears streaming into her matted fur. "They approved me. Back pay. Enough to—to hire someone. *Permanently*."

Adora's knees hit the floor. "Catra! That's *amazing*!" She pulled her into a crushing hug, trembling. "I'm so proud of you. So, so proud."

Catra buried her face in Adora's neck, the words spilling out—*three years, twice a week, maybe even PT*—between jagged breaths. Adora rocked her, repeating "*thank you, thank you, thank you*" into her ear, as if the phrase could stitch them both back together.

They sank to the floor, clinging. For the first time in months, Catra's claws didn't prick Adora's skin.

One Month Later

Perfuma's incense smelled like a meadow after rain. Catra wrinkled her nose. "Do you *have* to burn that stuff?"

"It's grounding!" Perfuma beamed, adjusting Catra's sleeve. The new aide wore a linen tunic embroidered with sunflowers and talked to houseplants like they were friends. Annoying. Weirdly comforting.

"There!" Perfuma stepped back, admiring her work—Catra in soft sweatpants, fur brushed into auburn waves. "You're radiant."

"I'm *tolerable*," Catra grumbled, but her tail flicked with something like pride.

Adora burst in, gym bag slung over her shoulder, and froze. Catra sat at the table, clean and alert, slotting a puzzle piece into a half-

finished galaxy.

"Hey, Adora." Catra didn't look up, but her ear twitched—a tell.

Adora's eyes burned. She crossed the room in three strides, cupping Catra's face, thumbs sweeping her cheeks. *Here. Alive. Safe*.

"Gross, you're sweaty," Catra muttered, but leaned into the touch.

"You're glowing," Adora whispered.

"It's the incense. Gives me a headache."

Adora laughed, wet and bright, pressing their foreheads together.

Perfuma slipped out, humming.

Later, there would be challenges—Perfuma's upcoming vacation, the hunt for a temporary aide, days when Catra's joints refused to cooperate. But here, now—Adora's calloused hands cradling hers, the puzzle glowing between them—was enough.

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